



Reconnecting Jackson Ward

Mapping the people affected by the Interstate Construction in 1950 in Jackson Ward, Richmond.

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Project Background

- The 1950s Interstate Highway Act connected much of America, yet paradoxically led to disconnection for certain marginalized communities.
- One of such communities was a thriving black community in Richmond, Virginia called Jackson Ward.
- The construction of I-95 and I-64 roads led to the displacement of many Jackson Ward residents.
- Today, Jackson Ward remains divided: one side of the interstate experiences gentrification and is known as Jackson Ward, while the other side consists mainly of low-income neighborhoods, like Gilpin Court.

Goals and Intended Outcomes

- As part of the Jackson Ward Community Plan, the City government wanted to address and better understand the displacement in the 1950s.
- To get a more in-depth look and better understanding about Jackson Ward pre-separation using Census Data and Sanborn Maps.
- Prioritizing user-friendly designs for locator tools, ensuring easy access for individuals, researchers, urban planners, historians, and the broader public.

Partnership

- Collaborative Project between the City of Richmond's Department of Planning and Development Office of Equitable Development and the University of Richmond's Spatial Analysis Lab (SAL)
- University of Richmond's SAL was responsible for the data work (transcription, georeferencing, geolocating), and creation of the geospatial tools for locating.
- City of Richmond Planning Department's was responsible for organization of the projection, the financial commitment, and connecting the SAL students with local community groups
- Through iterative collaborative meetings between May and July 2023 the tools and project were refined through a public presentation to engaged community members and groups (ex. Concerned Citizens of Gilpin Court) for further improvement on user experience/interface of the geospatial locator tools.
- Continued testing and refinement August 2023 to January 2024.

Methodology

Transcription of 1950s US census data after the "72" year rule" that records are released

Georeferenced 1930s Sanborn Fire Insurance Maps onto contemporary Map in ArcGIS Pro

Created locator tools through ESRI AGOL applications

Geocoded ~18,000 addresses onto the contemporary map on ArcGIS Pro

Engaged with the community and refined the tools for the best user experience

Inserted the locator tools into our ESRI Dashboard and will soon go live on RVA Planning Website

Figure 1: Step by Step Methodology for Tool Creation and Community Impact

Address Locator Example

- If the address is known, but not the same of the person, one can search for it, and then the name of the people who lived there will show up.
- Further if just a street is known then searched, the locator will provide the information for all the people living on that street.
- Zooms into map and further information is given about who lived at the address.
- Provides the opportunity for seeing who else lived around that home
- Built through ESRI's ArcGIS Dashboards



Figure 2: Address Locator Tool Screenshot and Example

Person Locator Example

- Allows the user to search for people by first or last name.
- Zooms in to the layer and further information is given about the neighbors around them and the other residents of the home.
- Like the Address locator the user has the opportunity to click on the other neighbors after the zoom.
- Created using the ESRI ArcGIS Online Instant Applications "inset" map option.



Figure 3: Person/Name Locator Tool Screenshot and Example

Information on Residents



Figure 4: 1950 Jackson Ward Residents and the location of I-95 Interstate

- Following the completion of the highway construction, a significant impact was observed in the demographic displacement. Approximately 2,650 Black individuals, juxtaposed with only 10 white individuals, were potentially affected by this development.
- The displacement of 2,650 Black individuals accounted for a notable proportion, comprising around 20.7% of the total Black population within the historic neighborhood. This disproportion in the impact of displacement underscores the disproportionate effects of such infrastructural changes on specific communities within the area.

Impacts and Outcomes

- Establishes a comprehensive resource to help individuals discover information about their loved ones, offering insights into their residences and the impact of construction on their lives.
- Organizes interactive community sessions, fostering direct conversations with present-day residents to gather feedback and enhance the effectiveness of these tools.
- Aims to make these widely accessible by featuring them prominently on the City of Richmond's official website for easy and universal public access.

Future Project Directions

- Enhancing community involvement through extensive testing of interactive dashboards, ensuring usability and relevance.
- Following more testing and focus groups, the applications have a tentative public release date in February of 2024.
- Expanding the coverage area beyond historic "Jackson Ward" official City designation to encompass the broader perceived Jackson Ward neighborhood boundaries.
- Introduces community mapping tools for past and present Jackson Ward residents to share their stories

